



provide the Royals with a rare combination of stability and explosiveness. The left-right combination has scored 933 runs for the first wicket in 28 innings in the IPL at an eye-catching run rate of 8.88. Jaiswal's recent exploits in Test cricket — **he scored two double-hundreds against England** — will only add to his confidence going into the IPL.

LSG

Much like Rajasthan Royals, Lucknow Super Giants also has a well-settled left-right opening

partnership in Quinton de Kock and KL Rahul. LSG, though, will be sweating over the fitness of skipper Rahul, who injured his quadriceps during the England Test series. It also doesn't help that de Kock had an unflattering SA20 campaign, where the left-hander averaged 19.36 with a strike rate of 123.12. The addition of left-handed batter Devdutt Padikkal offers LSG another option to structure its opening combination.

SRH

After trying seven different pairs

Kicking up a storm: Virat Kohli and Faf du Plessis formed the most successful opening pair of IPL 2023, scoring 939 runs in 14 innings, with five 50-plus and three 100-plus partnerships. SPORTZPICS/IPL

up top last season, Sunrisers Hyderabad enters IPL 2024 without a definite answer to who its openers are. **With the Hyderabad-based side spending nearly Rs. 7 crore on Travis Head, it only seems likely that the Australian ODI World Cup hero will be slotted at the top of the order.** While the experienced Mayank Agarwal is the most plausible partner for Head, all-rounder Abhishek Sharma, Anmolpreet Singh, and Rahul Tripathi offer a few more alternatives as well.

PBKS

Prabhsimran Singh's maiden IPL hundred, against Delhi Capitals last season, is likely to give him a longer rope as the Punjab Kings opener, alongside skipper Shikhar Dhawan. Dhawan, though, will be expected to do much of the heavy lifting, with the left-hander scoring nearly 20 per cent of his team's runs in both seasons with Punjab Kings. The Kings also have the option of bringing in the explosive Jonny Bairstow, which would, though, come at the cost of team balance.

MI

The five-time champion Mumbai Indians will deploy Rohit Sharma and Ishan Kishan at the top. **Freed from the captaincy responsibilities** — as Hardik Pandya takes over the reins for MI this season — Rohit is expected to lead the charge with the bat. Meanwhile, his opening partner, Ishan, will have a point to prove after he missed out on a central contract. Together, Ishan and Rohit have amassed 963 runs over the past two seasons and remain pivotal to the team's fortunes, even after the latter has